FASS 4TH WORKSHOP

CONTEMPORARY SECURITY ISSUES

22ND JUL - 2ND AUG, 2024 | POST EVENT REPORT

THEMATIC AREAS

- Regional security
- Climate Deterrence
- Media and National Security
- Emerging Technologies
- Pakistan's Foreign Policy
- Securitization of Discourse
- Multilateral Arms Control
- Maritime Security
- Space and Deterrence
- Nuclear Technology
- Geo-economics
- Crisis Simulation



SPEAKERS



Amb. (Retd)
JALIL ABBAS JILANI



Amb. (Retd)
ZAMIR AKRAM



DR.
SALMA MALIK



Amb. (Retd)
Abdul Basit



Mr. Oves Anwar



Amb. Tahir
Hussain Andrabi



Dr.
Adil Sultan



Mr. Leo Wigger



Dr.
Hassan Daud



Mr. Felix Kolbitz

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CONFRENCE OVERVIEW



The Faculty of Aerospace and Strategic Studies (FASS) at Air University, Islamabad, in collaboration with Friedrich-Ebert-Stiftung (FES) Pakistan, hosted a one-day international conference on the emerging challenges in global and regional security. The event featured insightful discussions addressing critical contemporary security issues.

The event featured discussions on contemporary security issues, the impact of emerging technologies, and regional security challenges. Proceedings were inaugurated by Dr. Adil Sultan, Dean of FASS, with an overview of FASS's initiatives, highlighting the department's growth and achievements over four years, including academic programs, internships, workshops, and international collaborations. Vice Chancellor Air University, Air Marshal Abdul Moeed Khan, delivered the keynote address, highlighting the need for intellectual engagement among young scholars to understand and respond to 21st-century security issues. FES Country Director, Mr. Felix Kolbitz, extended greetings on behalf of FES and emphasized the significance of education and capacity-building initiatives. Ambassador Masood and Mr. Jalil Abbas elaborated on the global geopolitical landscape, touching upon US-China relations, regional complexities, and Pakistan's strategic positioning in a multipolar world.

The conference featured three panels addressing diverse topics:
Panel 1: Emerging Regional and International Security Environment
Panel 2: Emerging Technologies and International Security
Panel 3: Challenges and Opportunities for Regional Security

The conference was a testament to FASS's commitment to nurturing intellectual discourse on pressing global issues. Through collaboration, critical analysis, and policy-oriented discussions, it served as a platform for fostering innovative ideas to shape a secure and prosperous future.



INAUGURAL PANEL



Dr. Adil Sultan welcomed distinguished guests to the conference, emphasizing its focus on contemporary issues and policy implications, and honoring Ambassador Jilani. He highlighted the importance of addressing leadership challenges and external security threats, noting that academia has a responsibility in these areas. Dr. Sultan also reflected on the growth of FASS since 2020, including the establishment of various programs and the organization of multiple conferences, workshops, and seminars. He stressed the importance of ensuring students' conceptual clarity through conference-related activities and highlighted the interdisciplinary support from his team.



Air Marshal Abdul Moeed Khan appreciated the efforts of the organizing team, discussed significant global security changes in the 21st century, and stressed the importance of intellectual engagement for young scholars to understand and address these issues. He highlighted the critical role of the FASS annual conference in shaping a secure future.



Mr. Felix Kolbitz from FES extended warm greetings and highlighted FES's role in education and capacity building since World War II. He emphasized the organization's collaboration with Pakistani institution, , and thanked the organizers for their efforts.

Mr. Jalil discussed the contemporary global geopolitical landscape, focusing on the rise of China and the resurgence of Russia. He highlighted the negative impacts of sanctions on Russia, the U.S. policy of containing China, and the technological debates surrounding the South China Sea. He also addressed the conflicts in Gaza and Israel, the implications of Iran's defensive actions, and the ongoing concerns in Afghanistan. He also discussed the lack of dialogue between Pakistan and India since 2019, the challenges posed by the stalled SAARC process, and the complexities of India-Pakistan relations.



Ambassador Masood reflected on historical changes and the impact of U.S. policies post-9/11, highlighting China's economic success and initiatives like the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI). He discussed the challenges posed by American policies, the rise of new international forums like BRICS and SCO, and the ongoing conflicts in Ukraine and Gaza. He emphasized the need for realistic diplomatic approaches and the importance of managing relations with other global powers.



PANEL 1 - EMERGING REGIONAL AND INTERNATIONAL SECURITY ENVIRONMENT



In the first panel, **Ambassador Zamir Akram** discussed global geopolitical dynamics, starting with the Cold War's end in 1991 and the subsequent rise of a U.S.-led global order. He highlighted the ideological struggle between the U.S. and the Soviet Union, which reshaped the global order, and noted the U.S.'s unilateral approach to international affairs, exemplified by its involvement in Iraq, Syria, and Afghanistan. Akram emphasized the current multipolar global order, marked by the rise of China and the resurgence of Russia, and discussed key developments such as NATO's expansion, the Ukraine crisis, and tensions in Palestine, Taiwan, and the South China Sea. He also addressed the ongoing humanitarian crisis in Palestine, where U.S. involvement in supporting Israel raises concerns of potential Iranian retaliation, including the possibility of nuclear conflict. Furthermore, he stressed that Pakistan's strategic ties with China necessitate a balanced approach to avoid entanglement in global power politics. **Dr. Salma Malik** introduced the concept of minilateralism, which involves engaging a small group of states to address specific challenges more efficiently than broader multilateral frameworks. She emphasized that developments in China directly impact Pakistan. **Ambassador Abdul Basit** discussed India's reluctance to engage in talks with Pakistan, highlighting terrorism as a serious issue and the lack of regional economic cooperation. He stressed that without addressing core disputes, relations between Pakistan and India cannot improve, noting the absence of dialogue since August 2019.











PANEL 2 - EMERGING TECHNOLOGIES AND INTERNATIONAL SECURITY

The panel brought forward critical discussions on the profound implications of modern advancements such as artificial intelligence (AI), quantum computing, and gene-editing technologies on global security. **Mr. Oves Anwar** highlighted the rising challenge of attribution, especially in the context of AI-driven drones and other autonomous systems that can make targeting and kill decisions. These technologies raise complex questions about accountability and compliance with humanitarian laws, such as the Geneva Conventions. For instance, AI's ability to distinguish between civilians and combatants and assess proportionality ensuring civilian harm does not outweigh military advantage remains uncertain. He also warned of potential misuse of emerging technologies, like the creation of ethnic bioweapons via CRISPR gene editing, capable of targeting entire populations, posing a grave threat to humanity. Furthermore, AI-based viruses and vulnerabilities in quantum and virtual currency systems exacerbate the need for robust defense mechanisms. However, the pace of technological evolution often outstrips legal frameworks, leaving significant gaps in international law regarding accountability and proportionality in warfare.

Mr. Tahir Hussain Andrabi added depth to the conversation by focusing on Lethal Autonomous Weapons (LAWs), colloquially known as "killer robots." These systems, which operate without human intervention, pose ethical dilemmas and risks of misuse. LAWs, while efficient for combat and surveillance roles, are prone to errors, raising the potential for unintended civilian harm and violations of international humanitarian law. Mr. Andrabi emphasized the need for robust testing, transparency, and accountability in their development and deployment to prevent exacerbation of existing conflicts or the creation of new ones. He noted the potential for LAWs to fundamentally alter the nature of warfare, shifting the moral responsibility from humans to machines.

Dr. Adil Sultan underscored the dual-edged nature of emerging technologies, which offer immense opportunities but also unprecedented risks. He discussed the transformative potential of quantum technologies in computing, encryption, and sensing, while cautioning that such advancements could deepen global disparities and render current security measures obsolete. Additionally, innovations like underwater robots and drones are reshaping maritime and aerial security landscapes. Dr. Sultan highlighted the importance of ethical considerations, international cooperation, and proactive policymaking to maximize benefits while mitigating risks.

Together, these discussions illuminated the critical intersections of technology, ethics, and international law, urging global policymakers to address these challenges with foresight and collaboration.







PANEL 3 - CHALLENGES AND OPPURTUNITIES FOR REGIONAL SECURITY

Panel 3 highlighted diverse perspectives on fostering cooperation, economic growth, and addressing global challenges. **Leo Wigger** emphasized the evolving role of the European Union (EU) in global affairs, noting its increasing responsibility in security and military collaboration post-9/11. He underscored the EU's shift toward a more unified and assertive global position, driven by economic factors and strengthened inter-member cooperation. Regarding EU-Pakistan relations, he observed a decline in focus but reaffirmed the relationship's critical importance. However, efforts to enhance security cooperation have fallen short of expectations, signaling a need for reevaluation of strategies and a realistic approach by Pakistan to its global role.



Mr. Hassan Dawood emphasized regional integration as a key driver of economic growth and connectivity, advocating for Pakistan to strengthen ties with Central Asia and beyond. He highlighted the potential of Pakistan's textile industry, particularly in hospital bed linen exports to China, and the transformative power of e-commerce and digital connectivity in reducing inequality. Drawing inspiration from China's success, he called for collective growth efforts, significant energy savings, and investments in regional connectivity. Mr. Dawood encouraged focusing on initiatives like the Pakistan Regional Economic Integration Activity (PREIA) to boost trade and unlock new markets, emphasizing the broader economic opportunities of regional integration.





Mr. Felix Kolbitz, Country Director of Friedrich-Ebert-Stiftung (FES), stressed the importance of transnational cooperation and youth empowerment in addressing global challenges such as climate change and inequality. He highlighted the role of youth as drivers of innovation and social change, while acknowledging barriers like limited access to education and decision-making processes. To overcome these, FES has launched initiatives like "Young Leaders for Change," fostering collaboration, resource sharing, and networking opportunities for youth. By empowering young leaders and promoting cooperation across borders, Mr. Kolbitz argued, nations could create a brighter, more equitable future.



Together, the panelists presented a compelling vision of regional integration, transnational collaboration, and youth-driven change as critical pathways for addressing modern challenges and fostering sustainable development.



MOMENTS FROM THE CONFRENCE

























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